Notes for photographers

Written by the author of this fork, from his own photographs, October 2026.

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A portrait with motion and defocus blur



Top left: original. Bottom left: deblurred. Right side: result.

The top left below is a cutout portrait of my favourite chicken/escape artist. It was taken with my 1957 Jupiter 9 85mm lens. Because she doesn't listen to me when I order her 'Stay Still' there is some motion and out of focus blur. No matter what I did and what type of sharpening I did in Affinity it just didn't look natural.

I took the cutout of the head and ran it through the deblur program with the result (bottom left) and then used Affinity to merge/blend the enhanced image into the original image with the result

on the right side. See the second image, it may not look like much, but sometimes I need to elevate an important image without introducing fake AI artifacts.

Deblurring vs. sharpening vs. AI enhancement



The Grand Bazaar with a history of over 5 centuries, Iran (1977, the year the Eaton Centre was opened) Kodak Kodachrome 64.

Imagine a satellite trying to read a license plate on the ground. The satellite's motion during the shot and the wavy atmosphere smear each letter into a fuzzy streak. Since you don't know the exact smear, the software estimates the most likely kind of blur that could have caused that fuzziness, reverses it, then adjusts its guess and tries again until the letters come back into focus. The information is still there—just smeared—and deblurring tries to un-smear it using its best guess.

This is different from sharpening, which just makes the fuzzy streaks look punchier, not readable. And it's different from AI enhancing, which might guess a plausible license plate number based on patterns it has seen—but could just as easily guess wrong. Deblurring tries to recover what was actually there; the other two don't.

The image above was a deblur of the full sized image then the result was subsequently merged with the original image to enhance the signs, the people and activity.

Where it doesn't help



Sometimes, as in this case, due to a toy film camera your holiday shot turns out to be useless. Using deblur on a social media sized crop can just maybe look good enough to post.

Also sometimes it can be used on a large sized image in place of sharpening. The result is more organic than other methods. But this only works on some images. Apply IFAN to the full size version of the image above results in too many artifacts. Trying to deblur structures at full resolution on an image like the one above is a pointless task.

Provenance. The photographs here are the author's own. The hen was taken with a 1957 Jupiter 9 85 mm lens; the bazaar is a 1977 Kodak Kodachrome 64 slide, later digitised by the author; the hill town is a 1970s toy-camera frame. They appear here as they do in the typeset note.

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